

LDC

The Living and Learning Design Centre









A world-class Crafts Museum dominates the landscape of Shrujan's Living and Learning Design Centre. Set up in 2016, LLDC as this institution is also called, is dedicated to preserving and promoting the tangible and intangible crafts and cultural heritage of Kutch.

Kutch is a district in the state of Gujarat in India with many diverse geologies and ecosystems including the salt desert, grasslands, thorn forests, mangroves and a long coastline. Over centuries, this diversity drew many communities from Central Asia and other parts of Asia to migrate to Kutch and settle in the ecosystems that best suited their traditional occupations.

The migrating communities enriched Kutch with their culture and especially their crafts. They also imbibed, respected and honoured the culture and values of Kutch, their new homeland.

This is how Kutch became home to 30 traditional crafts.

These are living crafts, and some like Ajrakh block printing, weaving and embroidery are world famous. The richness and variety of so many crafts; the skill and artistry of so many craftspeople, all thriving side by side in just one district, is a rare phenomenon not only in India but also in the world.

This makes Kutch a unique region and gives The Living and Learning Design Centre its meaning and purpose.



**The Living and Learning Design Centre – LLDC
is multidimensional. Its mission is to:**

preserve, promote and support traditional crafts
and their contemporary expressions

conduct participatory field research of craft communities
and their tangible and intangible crafts heritage

provide design support and skill enhancement
to practising craftspeople

motivate and equip the younger generation with knowledge
and skills to prepare them for a career in a craft of their choice

engage with a wide range of visitors including art and
craft lovers, textile experts, museum curators, conservators,
designers, scholars and researchers, officials from the
government and the civil services, as well as students
from schools and universities.



In this way, LLDC attends to every tangible and intangible aspect of a craft: preservation and conservation; revival and promotion; research and education, and documentation and dissemination.

LLDC also promotes the traditional culture of Kutch – its music, song, dance, drama, folk stories and cuisine. There is wealth and wisdom in the culture of Kutch, and especially in its oral histories with its central themes of love for nature and brotherhood of all people.



Grand in scale and scope, The Living and Learning Design Centre is spread over a nine-acre campus in Ajrakhpur in rural Kutch.

LLDC's architecture and design, its presence in a crafts-abundant location, affirms its commitment to the crafts and cultural heritage of Kutch.





LLDC is the vision of the late Chanda Shroff.

Her work with the crafts sector of Kutch began in 1969, when she established Shrujan, a not-for-profit, non-governmental social enterprise that has been a pioneer in craft revival and craft entrepreneurship.

Chanda Shroff was the first to recognize that the craftswomen's skill of embroidery could empower them to earn a home-based, dignified and sustainable livelihood.

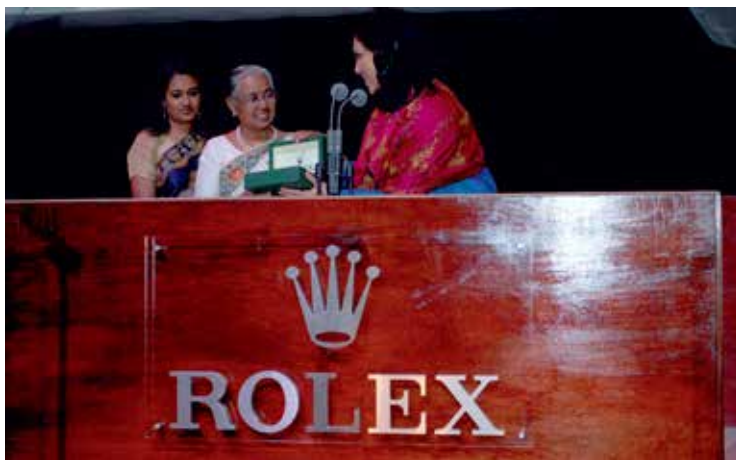
During its 55-year-long journey, Shrujan has enabled more than 20,000 craftswomen living in 120 remote villages to become self-sufficient. The empowerment has earned them respect in their families and raised their status in their communities. They have also been recognized as artists, and honoured with national and international awards.

Chanda Shroff also received international recognition when she was honoured with the Rolex Award for Enterprise. She became the first Indian Laureate to receive this prestigious award.



At that time, elders of craft communities to whom she was beloved, asked Chanda Shroff to pledge that she would do for all the crafts what she had done for embroidery.

Chanda Shroff kept her promise.
She gave Kutch, The Living and Learning Design Centre.



LLDC's star attraction is its international standard Crafts Museum with its three Galleries. Other features include the Hands-On Experience Space, the Archives, and Conservation Facilities.

The Main Gallery features a Show titled The Living Embroideries of Kutch, which is a celebration of the embroidery traditions of twelve communities. Some of the communities such as the Mutva and the Jat practise more than five embroidery styles. This diversity and abundance makes the Show rich in content and visual beauty.

The objects on display showcase the splendour of the past as well as the equally magnificent creations of present-day craftswomen. Outstanding among them are the large-size embroidered textile panels that showcase the highest standards of creative and technical excellence achieved anywhere in the modern world.

The Shows in the second Gallery called Under the Embroidered Sky Gallery focus on the embroidery tradition of a specific community of Kutch. The content of each Show emerges from the data collected by the field research team of LLDC.

The first Show, for example, was all about the bold and lush-with-mirrors embroidery of the Ahir and Meghwaad Gurjar communities. It traced the journey of this embroidery from its role as a personal craft and a marker of cultural identity, to its transformation as a means of dignified livelihood, to its present-day avatar as exquisite art.



This Gallery currently features 'The Embroideries of the Mutva Community of Banni.' This Show provides an overview of this once remote and inaccessible region and the transformation that has taken place over the past fifty years. Today, Banni is a vital, mainstream, income-generating part of Kutch.

The Show calls attention to the role that Shrujan and embroidery have played in this transformation. It also brings to life the Mutva embroidery universe with its 19 distinct styles of embroidery. And, it traces the journey of this embroidery right up to its present-day avatar as one of the beloved embroideries for those who cherish the work of the hand.

The third Gallery is the Inspiration Gallery. It curates shows primarily for the craft communities of Kutch. Each show features the arts and crafts of a specific region of the world. Local craftspeople say that the Shows are their introduction to the passions and preoccupations of fellow craftspeople. They also broaden their horizon, stimulate their creativity and influence their craft practice in wondrous ways.

A unique feature of all the Shows in the Crafts Museum is the participation of craftspeople. They feel a sense of ownership and are involved in every aspect, from the choice of exhibits to setting up the displays.

The Hands-On Experience Space invites visitors to try their hand at block printing, clamp dyeing, pottery, weaving and embroidery. Even a brief live encounter with crafts creates an appreciation of the creativity, skill, precision and patience demanded by the work of the hand. This in turn leads to an understanding of why crafts are so revered and cherished.

The Archives house the permanent Museum Collection which comprises more than 11,000 textile and non-textile objects from Kutch as well as from other parts of India and the world.

The Conservation Facilities play an important role; its conservators have expertise in preserving fragile textiles in the tropical climate of India.





LLDC has a Crafts Research Department.

Its most monumental project is creating an authoritative and comprehensive documentation of the 30 crafts of Kutch.

The starting point is the research conducted in the field using a participatory research methodology. The community, the craftspeople and their oral histories are the primary sources of information and insights. Technical details regarding the language of each craft as well as the process of producing it are also documented in print, audio and video formats.

The research data creates the foundation of all the Museum Shows. They appeal in different ways to different generations: practising craftspeople are astonished and delighted by the rediscovery of long-forgotten aspects of their craft. For the younger generation, the Shows provide a deep dive into the glories of their heritage, and motivate them to begin their journey to learn and practice their family craft.





Craft education and training takes place through training workshops, panel discussions, lectures and seminars.

Craft Workshops focus on creative aspects such as innovations in design and product development. These intensive sessions give craftspeople an opportunity to pursue their individual passions and push through conventional boundaries that separate craft from art.

At the Embroidery Revival Workshops craftswomen practise stitches, motifs and designs and other lost treasures rediscovered during field research. This 'giving back' to the craftswomen and the communities enlarges the repertoire of the craftswomen and also strengthens the bonds between them and LLDC.

Creativity Enhancement Workshops encourage craftswomen to dream and imagine new ways of interpreting the language of their embroidery tradition while remaining true to its core values.



Cultural Programs and Events take place all through the year. They include exhibitions; music and dance recitals; dialogues with the living legends of the crafts; felicitation of outstanding craftspeople; and, art and craft competitions for school children as well as amateur and professional artists.

An annual event at LLDC is the Winter Festival. It is a dual celebration: of the performing arts, crafts and cuisine of Kutch, as well as of one state of India.

The Festival is a much awaited event for the people of Kutch, the partnering state and visitors from India and abroad. The sense of togetherness, inclusion and camaraderie makes the five-day long celebration truly memorable.



Support

The arts and crafts of Kutch are the precious heritage of all humanity. Your support can help millions of people to experience the life-enhancing power of art, craft and culture.





There are many ways you can be of help.

You can support LLDC's programming, conservation, research and other activities such as a Museum Show, or the Winter Festival.

You can help enhance our Museum Collection through special acquisitions.

You can leave a gift in your Will; donate in memory of a loved one.

You can remember LLDC in your Will for object repatriation.

We look forward to a relationship with you as a personal funder or a facilitator for a contribution through a Foundation/ a Corporate by way of CSR.

Do get in touch with us to learn more about how you can help us.

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- ▶ **LLDC Virtual Tour**
- ▶ **Introduction to LLDC Craft Museum**

**LLDC: the only rural-based institution
committed to
all the crafts and all the craftspeople of Kutch**

**LLDC: safeguards the past
celebrates the present
secures the future
of crafts and the cultural heritage of Kutch**

**LLDC: a one-stop destination
for art and crafts lovers of the world.**

**Timings :
9.30am to 6.00pm
Tuesday to Sunday | Monday Closed.**



Living & Learning
Design Centre

Museum • Craft research
Shop • Café



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